Thailand and Myanmar, and even from Chinese NGO Green Watershed in Kunming.[8]

Spokesmen for the Chinese authorities claim that ‘there are cooperation mechanisms for China and the five Southeast Asian countries (Myanmar, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia, and Vietnam) that can help co-ordinate sustainable use of water resources in the Lancang-Mekong River and share information’.[9] The problem is that there are actually very few such ‘co-operation mechanisms’ between China and the downstream countries. China is not a member of the Mekong River Commission, an intergovernmental body for co-ordinating water resources comprising representatives of Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam. Myanmar, which does not significantly rely on or tap the Mekong, attends meetings as an observer, as does China, but the Chinese only provide water level data to the Commission during floods. None of the downstream countries was consulted before China built its dams on the Mekong. China has built seven such dams so far, and plans to build 21 more.[10]

In Myanmar, Chinese plans to build a mega dam at Myitsone, where the Mali Hka and the Nmai Hka join to become the Irrawaddy River, rivers that do not flow from China, provoked mass protests until the country’s new quasi-civilian government under President Thein Sein announced on 30 September, 2011, that the joint Myanmar-Chinese mega-hydroelectric project was suspended. The US$3.6 billion Myitsone Dam would have been world’s 15th tallest dam, submerging 766 square kilometres of forestland, an area bigger than Singapore.[11] The suspension of the construction of the dam marked the beginning of rapidly deteriorating relations between Myanmar and China. Until then, Myanmar had been one of China’s most faithful allies in Southeast Asia.

Hu Weijia, writing in the *Global Times* in October 2016, argued that ‘it is understandable that India is sensitive to China’s water exploitation on the Brahmaputra as a downstream country, but China is unlikely to use the waters of the river as a potential weapon … China-India relations should not be affected by an imaginary “water war”.’[12] The problem is that there already is a ‘water war’, although it has not led to armed conflict and may never do so. But the dispute is bound to exacerbate the already strained relations between India and China.